

A Case of Cabinets

Agent 001 jumps into the world of cabinets

It all started out as a great morning. The day looked promising. I'd just taken a sip of my morning coffee, when my secret-agent communication device sounded an SOS. Answering the device, which is cleverly designed to look like a cell phone, I learned that a friend's antique Celeron processor had just died. He was inviting me to the funeral, which involved a little newspaper wrapping and a quick burial in the local dustbin, and then a desperate trip to find a better replacement. He had decided on an Intel motherboard and a Pentium 4 CPU, but had no clue about what cabinet to buy.

Not one to miss out on a tech-shopping spree, I met him at the now infamous Lamington Road, in south Mumbai. A quick scan of my super-secret black book told me that I was close to a dealer I had bought from earlier. He didn't remember me though, but was polite enough to lie, "Kaise hain aap? Haven't seen you for a long time". My friend quickly detailed his requirements—something large and airy that would hold all of his 7,65,23,476 peripherals. Off went the vendor, and disappeared into a secret crevice that only he knew existed—the shop could hold three, four if you wanted to be better acquainted with someone. He returned, carrying a rather ordinary looking beige and blue Frontech mini-tower cabinet. Priced at Rs 1,250, it had a 300W power supply, which he claimed was "Full 300W. Substandard nahi hai!", and also came with a 1 year warranty. It

had vents for fans, but we weren't convinced. After another quick disappearing act, he came back with an Intex cabinet that cost Rs 1,300. It had adequate drive bays, a 300W SMPS and a year's warranty. Though it had everything that you'd need such as air vents and fans, many colours to choose from and a spacious interior, we weren't convinced just yet. We bid him farewell and moved on to find a little more variety.

The next shop we walked into had a better feel to it. It was spacious, had a look of professionalism and had a well dressed vendor behind the counter. As soon as we mentioned cabinets, he asked what CPU and motherboard combination we had. "If you are buying a Pentium 4 it's fine, but if you have an Athlon, you have to be very careful," he warned us. "Athlons heat up a lot more than Pentiums. If you have other high-end equipment such as a GeForce graphics card, it's going to be hot in there and you'll need additional fans". He showed us a Mercury Oscar cabinet for Rs 1,400. It came with a one year warranty, many cooling vents at the back and a 300W SMPS. When we asked to see something better, he

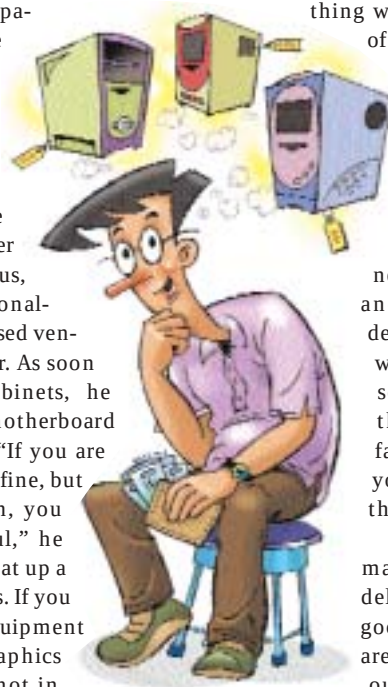
showed us an iBox and an unheard of VIP brand of cabinets that cost Rs 1,500 each. The VIP looked really good, and he said it was a local brand, but had a rock-steady power supply—good for over-clocking. The VIP had easy-to-remove sliding panels and air vents by the dozen. It had everything we needed, but the unheard of branding sent us shop-hopping down the road.

The next store looked swanky as well, but the dealer started pulling out all these unheard of brands with ugly tacky-looking cabinets. They had lights galore, and looked like they were designed by the same person who decorates the insides of some of taxis. He could see the look of disdain on our faces, and asked, "Would you prefer to see the top of the line models?"

What he pulled out then made us almost squeal with delight. There are cabinets, good cabinets and then there are Antec cabinets. He pulled out a jaw-dropping model with thumb screws, remov-

able 3.5-inch bays and screwless locking for 5.25-inch devices—you can install just about anything without ever using a screwdriver. It had vents galore, a 350W SMPS and a blowhole. Now here's a real solution to ventilation. Instead of normal vents, blowholes on the top of the cabinet blow air out from just above the CPU fan. However, it cost Rs 6,500 and he wouldn't accept my undying gratitude—cash and credit cards only please.

An hour later, when I finally ran out of arguments and conceded that my friend could not sell his mother's jewellery, we decided that something a lot cheaper was best. We were left with two options: either a Mercury or VIP cabinet. Though I was more impressed with the features of VIP, my friend preferred to spend his money of a better known brand. The Mercury it was. I went back home dreaming of owning the best Antec there is. ■



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar



■ Insist on cases with adequate ventilation, with fixtures to help you mount fans. Look for rear and front vents.

■ Get extra fans mounted on the case, even if you don't intend to over-clock. It will provide better airflow and make your hardware run smoother and last longer.

■ 300W power supplies are standard and adequate for today's computers. Look for steady power supplies, as fluctuations in the power will cause lockups and damage hardware.

■ Choose a large cabinet: either a big

mini-tower, or tower cabinet. Make sure that it will hold your motherboard—MicroATX or ATX form factor. This aids ventilation and allows easy access to hardware.

■ Screw mounted blanking plates in the rear (that cover unused bays) are better than those that have to be broken. You can reattach these later when a bay is unused, preventing unnecessary exposure to dust.

■ Look for cases with thumb-screws or slide out access panels that let you open your cabinet easily.